‘Queen’, the king objected, ‘I am a ksatriya; how can I eat an onion?’

‘My lord’, she replied, ‘this is medicine; take it for the sake of life!’

Asoka then ate it; the worm died, and passed out through his intestines, and he fully recovered.[10]

Killing another woman’s ill husband to cure her own is not very dharmic, but as we have seen in relation to Kunala this was not a queen to be kept at bay by minor dharmic considerations when something desperate and compelling required doing. Women of decisive action and swift intervention in the lives of monarchs are something of a rarity in ancient India, making Tishyarakshita seem admirable for her singularly surgical way of dealing with life in difficult times.

The malevolence of his intelligent queen is expanded upon at length with Ashoka’s recovery, the grateful monarch granting Tishyarakshita a boon. She asks to be made the monarch for seven days, and, the wish granted, shows she has lost none of the old decisiveness by moving quickly to destroy Kunala. A letter addressed to the people of Taxila orders them to put out his eyes. After some understandable hesitation by the letter’s recipients, they do as requested and gouge the eyes out. The blinded Kunala and his wife return to Pataliputra where they learn of Tishyarakshita’s villainy. A furious Ashoka disowns her in a very un-Ashokan manner, threatening to tear her eyes out and ‘rip open her body with sharp rakes, impale her alive on a spit, cut off her nose with a saw, cut out her tongue with a razor, and fill her with poison and kill her.’[11] Kunala’s view of the matter, luckily, is less un-Buddhist than his father’s and he pleads forgiveness for her. This magnanimity results in his own sight returning but does not lead to absolution for the queen. On Ashoka’s orders, Tishyarakshita is burned to death in a ‘lacquer house’; for good measure, we are told, he ‘had the citizens of Taksasila executed as well.’[12]

There is clearly a recurrence of elements ascribed in the *Ashokavadana* to Ashoka’s last years which formed part of his life as a prince. Like